The Advancement of Learning

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Learning hath been delivered as a rich storehouse for the glory of the Creator and the relief of man's estate. But the manner of delivery hath not been answerable to the matter. Knowledge is commonly handled as if it were a body without joints, to be carried whole rather than opened and distributed.

For method is not a thing of ornament. It is the hand that guides the reader through a wilderness of particulars, and where method is wanting the reader wandereth, though the matter be good. Hence it is that many books are rather to be read than studied, and many more are studied to no purpose.

Let no man think that the dignity of learning is diminished by the care of its arrangement. The astronomer who orders the stars doth not thereby make them; he maketh them intelligible. So the writer who disposeth his matter in due order doth not invent truth, but rendereth it apt for use.

There is a kind of knowledge which may be called "a dry light," which shineth upon the understanding without warming the affections. It is the light of the schoolmen, subtle and barren; and it is the fault of the age that such light is often mistaken for the sun.

Yet we ought not to despise the fragments. A maxim, a sentence, a note in the margin may serve when the whole treatise is wanting. The reader who collects such fragments is not a borrower but a builder, and his building is the better for being made of pieces he hath chosen himself.

For the mind of man is not a vessel to be filled, but a lamp to be kindled. And a lamp is kindled by contact, not by instruction alone; wherefore the company of good books, and the notes we make in them, do more toward knowledge than the bare reading of many volumes.

Neither is this a defence of mere collection. To gather sentences without order is to heap stones

without a wall. The note must answer to the question that occasioned it, and the question must be one the reader can still recognise a month hence. Where that condition fails, the margin becomes a graveyard of good intentions.

I have therefore set down, in the following books, both the method and the impediments of method; not as a master, but as a surveyor who marks the ground before others build. If the reader find here a phrase worth his own margin, let him take it, and let him add to it.